

After Us



Anna Puteine and Krystyna Lopatych









The Setting and Core Idea



- The game takes place several decades after a collapse caused by overconsumption and pollution.
- Products were replaced instead of repaired, and waste piled up faster than nature could absorb it.
- The player is one of the few survivors and starts with almost nothing.
- The surroundings are full of plastic bottles, packaging, broken electronics, old clothes, and natural materials that people rarely think of as useful.
- Every item raises the same question: is it waste or a resource? The answer depends on what the player knows.







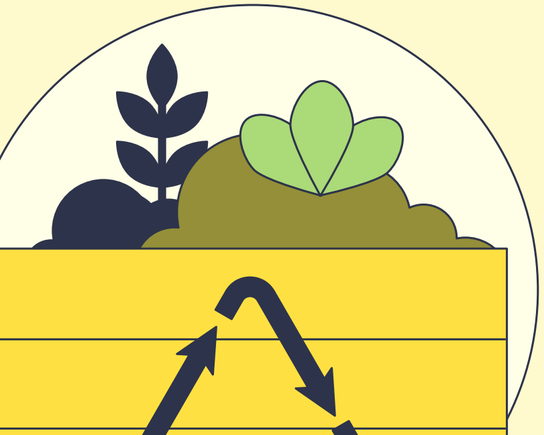


Real Green Inventions

- Most survival games use made-up crafting chains, like fire, then hammer, then axe. These teach nothing about the real world.
- In After Us, every recipe is based on a real green invention that is not widely known. The recipes are the main content of the game.

Examples:

  - A plastic bottle of water left in the sun becomes a solar water disinfector
  - Seaweed becomes edible packaging
  - Waste and organic leftovers become bioplastics
  - Mushroom-based materials replace plastic
  - Composting turns leftovers into soil for growing food
- Recipes are simplified for gameplay, but the ideas behind them are real.







Social Good Theme

- Everyone produces waste every day, but climate change and pollution feel too big and distant to be personal. We wanted a game that connects one small decision to its long-term result.
- What inspired us most were real inventions that show how valuable "trash" can be. Most people have never heard of them.
- Main audience: teenagers and young adults (about 15-25), who will live with the consequences the longest. Casual gamers are the second audience, so the game is a fun survival game first, not a lecture.
- Main UN goal: SDG 12 Responsible Consumption and Production.
- Also related: SDG 13 Climate Action, SDG 3 Good Health, SDG 14 and 15 Life Below Water and on Land, and SDG 11 Sustainable Cities.







Every Item Is a Decision

- The player can keep an item, reuse it, repair it, recycle it, or transform it. Throwing it away or burning it is also possible, and it is the fastest option.
- Transforming uses the real green inventions. It needs knowledge, materials, and a workbench, but it has the highest long-term payoff.
- Discarding is quick but adds pollution, and recycling is slow and needs energy. The player has to decide what the situation needs now and later.
- The world reacts right away: burning waste darkens the sky and worsens the air, and cleaning an area makes the water and ground look healthier.
- Sometimes the player needs a material that was thrown away earlier, such as a plastic bottle for water disinfection.





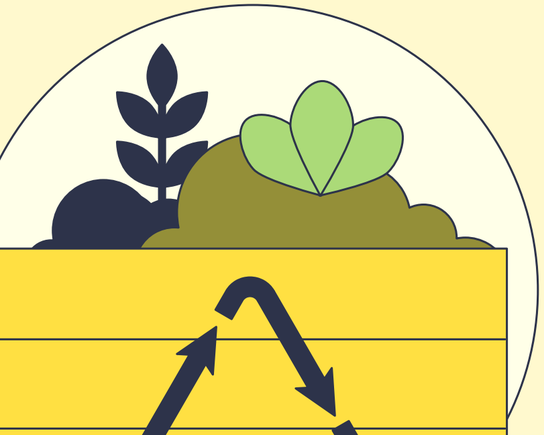






How the Game Progresses

- The game has five levels, each about 15-30 minutes. The player explores, collects items, decides what to do with them, and builds toward the level goal.
- The player keeps hunger, thirst, and health above zero and watches air pollution and temperature.
- The first level teaches the basic loop with familiar plastic waste. Later levels add pollution, climate extremes, scarcity, and new materials, and they unlock more of the lesser-known inventions.
- In the final level, the player uses the methods learned along the way to build a small sustainable settlement with clean water, low-impact energy, food, and a working recycling loop. The world is improved, not completely fixed.







Message and Testing

- The main message: discarded objects do not disappear, and with creativity many of them can become something useful again.
- Reusing and repairing is better than recycling, recycling is better than throwing away, and short-term convenience often causes long-term problems.
- By the end, the player should be able to explain at least one or two unusual recycling methods from the game.
- We will test with 4-10 players and a short survey: can they name and explain an unusual method, and did they notice how their choices changed the world?







What Makes Us Different

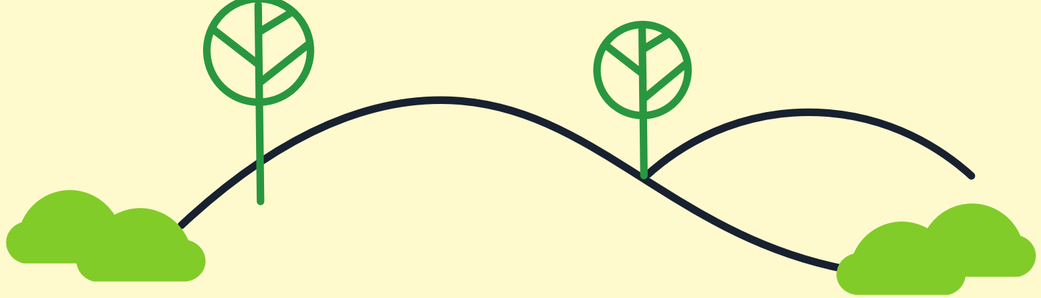
- Minecraft, Don't Starve, This War of Mine, Eco, and Terra Nil cover survival or ecology, and educational recycling games are usually simple sorting games. After Us combines these ideas in three ways:
  - Real, little-known green inventions are the gameplay, so the player learns concrete methods and not only that "pollution is bad"
  - Waste is part of the survival loop, and every used object is a decision
  - The message comes from experience in the game, not from text explanations
- The prototype is planned as a single-player web game for a team of two.













Thank You





